even in its last remaining stronghold. By extension, this bypoll also means a lot to CM Bhagwant Mann, being a sort of interim referendum. Mann has taken direct charge of the campaign, rallying MLAs, ministers and cadres to secure what he calls a "decisive urban endorsement" of his regime.

Arora is running a restrained campaign—centred around his clean image, business acumen and philanthropic work. His appeal is strongest among the industrial and trader classes, whom AAP has ardently courted. Locally, Arora's supporters admit the enthusiasm of 2022 has cooled, with civic complaints piling up. The promise of '*badlav*' now competes with an uncomfortable sense of drift.

THE YOUNG TURK

Sensing an opportunity to reclaim lost turf, the Congress has fielded the Ludhiana native Bharat Bhushan Ashu—a two-time former MLA with deep roots here and a score to settle. Currently working president of the state unit, his

Takeaways

- **AAP face Sanjeev Arora is an RS MP. If he wins, it opens a route for Kejriwal**
- **It's also a battle to renew faith in AAP's urban 'doer' image, against a strong Congress challenger**

2022 defeat was part of the larger Congress collapse, but he never lost touch with his constituents. Ashu has methodically rebuilt his ground presence, going door to door, visiting ward-level units, and reconnecting with civic groups and trade unions. His campaign draws heavily on his past as a doer, who delivered on civic issues, pushed through infrastructure projects and kept up a personal rapport with the city folk. His pitch is emotional: give me one more chance to serve, he says. The Congress, still struggling to find coherence post-Amarinder Singh, is watching hopefully: a win would signal urban resurgence.



CHIEF CHALLENGER Bharat Bhushan Ashu, Congress

Ashu, with a flowing white beard that can overstate his 54 years, is a tough-talking local business scion who was part of a corps selected for a greater role by Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over a decade ago, when he was attempting to groom a new generation of leaders in Punjab. Close to fellow 'young turk' and then Ludhiana MP Ravneet Singh Bittu, now a Union minister, the duo almost made it to a 'Battle of the Bosom Pals' in 2024 after the latter shifted to the BJP. Ashu stayed put in the GOP and is now invoking his decade-long record as legislator, towards whose end he was briefly cabinet minister.

The BJP, meanwhile, has nominated veteran Jiwan Gupta—investing in its own cadre after a long time, rather than in high-profile turncoats or transactional alliances. More than a realistic stab at an upset win, it's a "long-term investment". In a constituency with some 30 per cent Hindus, the two main opponents are also Hindu—so that's not particularly a USP.

It's tightly poised. AAP retains an edge, but Arora, a respected figure, is not the sort to set the barn on fire. That makes it a purer barometer of which way Punjab's politically orphaned urban voter will turn. ■



THE DAILY TOIL NREGA workers in Memari, West Bengal

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

▶ WEST BENGAL

NO END T

It's been over three years since the Centre paused funds to the job scheme in Bengal, alleging a scam. A bitter debate picks up ahead of polls

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

MUCH LABOUR HAS BEEN SPENT on this debate—never settled, it's gasping for capital too. Left marooned by New Delhi 40 months ago, West Bengal has had to dig into its own scanty coffers to keep work afloat under the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA). It's nearly not enough for the state's 138 million active job card holders. Consider the figures. Since March 2022, when the Centre suspended NREGA funds citing